concept document in February 2013, which establishes the BRICS as "one of the most important geopolitical events since the beginning of the new century," one that has rapidly become "a significant factor in global policy."[113]

Over time, the Kremlin has worked to transform the BRICS club into a more robust institution, widening the sphere of cooperation.[114] The BRICS has helped create a focal point around the importance of using financial statecraft to defend the autonomy of non-Western powers, but without turning the BRICS into an "anti-Western" club, despite Moscow's inclinations. The Kremlin welcomed the BRICS' support against the use of Western sanctions over Ukraine, including at successive leadership summits in 2014, 2015, and 2016. Russia also prudently backs the BRICS consensus that it would be "an exaggeration to assume that" the new BRICS institutions "could be an alternative to the IMF and World Bank," despite some loss of effectiveness in existing governance institutions. "To work properly, [BRICS institutions] must interact with the established institutions."[115] But Moscow is not content to be reformers from within the system; officials and elites believe that Russia should also play a key insider role in the "Green Rooms," which it considers would befit its role as a major power and its perceived comparative advantage from its long institutional experience brokering deals.[116]

This section expands on these insights and discusses Russia's unilateral and multilateral exercise of economic and financial statecraft as a clue to understanding Moscow's motivations for acting jointly around financial issues with the other BRICS and why it is more comfortable with its offensive financial statecraft than the BRICS club consensus. It focuses on six issues: Russia's aims vis-à-vis the incumbent powers and adjustment to a rising China; Russia's engagement with the global financial governance order prior to the BRICS; the priority attached to ensuring Russia's autonomy; the impact of Western financial sanctions and welcome support from its BRICS partners; Russia's interest in challenging the U.S. dollar's hegemony and a desired shift to a multipolar world while wary about the rise of the RMB; and finally how Russia blurs defensive and offensive instruments of financial statecraft.